possible to clarify when they were built. Some carry no inscriptions. In such instances, the basis on which the structures are said to have either been built or expanded is either literary—the authors of ancient texts describing them as built by the emperor—or else include elements generally considered diagnostic for identifying Ashokan edifices, such as polished pillars and the specific sorts of bricks used. Archaeological cultures are usually identified by ‘type fossils’. The archetypal objects of the Harappan civilization, for instance, range from long flint implements to rectangular and square inscribed seals. Similarly, pillars with the polish so typical of inscribed Ashokan pillars, as also religious structures made of bricks—which, in terms of size and fabric, resemble other structures built in this period and which have occasionally been found constructed on the same floors where the pillars stand—can be reliably identified as type fossils of Ashoka’s phase.

These locales perhaps had fixed or flexible associations with the sacred which may have been the initial reason for Ashoka’s journeys to and engagement with them, as for instance Lumbini, the Buddha’s birthplace. His visits to them were, however, often transformative—personally, they may have made him more devout, but, more important, via the structures he built there he changed the existing configurations and gave them new meaning. Other patrons may have done this as well, but Ashoka’s ability to influence sacred landscapes was much greater because massive monoliths and temples required large resources and labour. They also perhaps required, in many instances, reaching understanding with Buddhist monastic custodians. At some Buddhist sites Ashoka assumed the role of a religious instructor. As the powerhouse of belief in his day, ‘both a monk and monarch at the same time’,[1] he felt he was entitled to address the Buddhist Sangha on religious and doctrinal matters.

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